I made use of the same device I had used in "Super-Neutron" and in "Day of the Hunters/' one in which the story is told in the form of a conversation among congenial spirits. I sent it off to Horace and waited to hear.

I needed some good news, for the weather was warming again, and the attic apartment in Somerville was warming even faster. We dreaded another summer there—and a full one this time. Even a visit to the MIT science-fiction society on May 12, my first contact with Boston fandom, did nothing to cheer me up.

We seized the occasion of Mother's Day on May 14 to call our respective families, and there was news on both sides. Stanley, who was finishing his junior year at New York University, had been working on its newspaper steadily and had been elected co-editor-in-chief for the next year.

And as for Henry Blugerman, he was selling the Henry Paper Box Company. He had owned it five years and it had been a hellish time, for it had been marginal at best during the entire period.

For me, though, the important news came the next day, when I got a telegram from Brad to the effect that he liked the third version of The Stars, like Dust — and this time I was to complete the novel. There was no talk of contract; that would take place with Fred, who was now in business as the Dirk Wylie Literary Agency. (Dirk Wylie, with whom he had started it, was now dead, and Rosalind was a widow.) Fred wrote quickly and told me that The Stars, like Dust-would involve a $750 advance, half again as much as that which Pebble in the Sky had commanded.

In addition to that, he was peddling a short story of mine that I called "Flesh and Metal." It was an attempt on my part to write a robot story that would sell to the slick magazines a la Heinlein. It had a handsome robot in it, a smitten housewife, and a tables-turned Cinderella bit. I thought it couldn't miss.

It had, however been circulating all through 1949 and early 1950 and had been missing every time.

Finally, Amazing decided to turn classy and publish very literary material by paying $.05 a word—an absolutely unprecedented fee. Fred managed to place "Flesh and Metal" with them and got $250 for

merely 5,000 words. And Gold eventually accepted "Darwinian Poolroom/'

To top it off, Gertrude had completed the typing up of the robot collection by